

THE BRAZEN SERPENT

*POWER POINT SLIDE

**INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

TEXT: Numbers 21:1-9 (NKJV) *“The king of Arad, the Canaanite, who dwelt in the South, heard that Israel was coming on the road to Atharim, then he fought against Israel and took some of them prisoners. ²So Israel made a vow to the LORD, and said, “If You will indeed deliver this people into my hand, then I will utterly destroy their cities.” ³And the LORD listened to the voice of Israel and delivered up the Canaanites, and they utterly destroyed them and their cities. So the name of that place was called Hormah. ⁴Then they journeyed from Mount Hor by the Way of the Red Sea, to go around the land of Edom; and the soul of the people became very discouraged on the way. ⁵And the people spoke against God and against Moses: “Why have you brought us up out of Egypt to die in the wilderness? For there is no food and no water, and our soul loathes this worthless bread.” ⁶So the LORD sent fiery serpents among the people, and they bit the people; and many of the people of Israel died. ⁷Therefore the people came to Moses, and said, “We have sinned, for we have spoken against the LORD and against you; pray to the LORD that He take away the serpents from us.” So Moses prayed for the people. ⁸Then the LORD said to Moses, “Make a fiery serpent, and set it on a pole; and it shall be that everyone who is bitten, when he looks at it, shall live.” ⁹So Moses made a bronze serpent, and put it on a pole; and so it was, if*

a serpent had bitten anyone, when he looked at the bronze serpent, he lived.”

INTRO: Have you ever heard of the old saying, “*You can’t teach an old dog, new tricks?*” That’s the way the saying goes, now whether it’s true or not is debatable. Whether the statement is true or false, it points to a very basic flaw in human nature, people do become set in their ways, and besides that, most people are very predictable! Someone said, “*People can change, but not much.*” Leave on screen until next slide) Apart from the redemptive power of the cross and the work of the Holy Spirit in one’s life this is basically a true statement.

The principle of predictability is very true element of the character of the children of Israel. The story of their departure from Egypt and wanderings in the wilderness is the story of a rebellious nature born out of a slave mentality developed over a four hundred year period of Egyptian slavery! The Children of Israel rebelled against their human and divine authority and murmured and complained until God decided to send judgment upon their blasphemous ways!

Some of the darkest moments in Israeli history are the times when this nation unabashedly wondered out loud if it would be better off to return to Egyptian slavery rather than forge ahead into the future leaning on the

strong arm of the Lord who delivered them in the first place!

In Numbers chapter twenty one we find the Israelites have reverted to their old habits of murmuring, complaining, and throwing sand in the face of Jehovah! They are truly back to their old ways!

Thirty-eight years have passed since God led them out of Egyptian bondage! They were not permitted entrance into Canaan because of their unbelief. **The Israelites** quite literally **turned eleven day's journey into forty plus years of wilderness wandering!**
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

Does this sound familiar?

For thirty eight years God had sustained them; fed them; led them (by supernatural means); and delivered them from every crisis situation that threatened them, all the while negotiating a wilderness laden with pitfalls and dangers! They had witnessed the supernatural working of God's power, been eye-witnesses to God's glory, and had experienced the loving way in which Jehovah had dealt with them! Now a new crisis has developed and they stepped right up to the plate and flunked the test!

A group of Canaanites, led by King Arad, had ambushed the Israelites and captured some of them. As soon as this happened, the Israelites came running to the Lord with a vow and the enemy was destroyed!

Numbers 21:2-3 (NKJV) ***“So Israel made a vow to the LORD, and said, “If You will indeed deliver this people into my hand, then I will utterly destroy their cities.”³ And the LORD listened to the voice of Israel and delivered up the Canaanites, and they utterly destroyed them and their cities. So the name of that place was called Hormah.”***

As so often happened in the history of Israel, and as too often happens in our lives, this **great victory was followed by a terrible defeat! (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** The old problems of discouragement, disobedience, and rebellion began to surface and proved to be the downfall of this nomadic nation of emancipated slaves! Numbers 21:4-6 (NKJV) ***“Then they journeyed from Mount Hor by the Way of the Red Sea, to go around the land of Edom; and the soul of the people became very discouraged on the way.⁵ And the people spoke against God and against Moses: “Why have you brought us up out of Egypt to die in the wilderness? For there is no food and no water, and our soul loathes this worthless bread.”⁶ So the LORD sent fiery serpents among the people, and they bit the people; and many of the people of Israel died.”*** They became tired. We should be careful lest Satan would take advantage of us when we become physically and spiritually fatigued! They were discouraged, ***“Because of the way.”***

I am sure there were many in that company who remembered the miraculous deliverance from Egypt! There were still a great number in this multitude that had been stirred by God's power in the opening of the Red Sea! They had seen it with their eyes; they had been there when it happened; they were eyewitnesses of one of the greatest miracles in human history! They had personally marched through the Red Sea on dry land! Some of these people had stood on the bank of the Red Sea and sang the song of redemption as Egyptian chariots, soldiers, and paraphernalia washed up on the shoreline!

This nation of people had seen God's hand of mercy time and time again, as he provided water in the dry place, rained down manna from heaven, sent quail when they decided they did not like manna, and gave victory after victory!

This group of people was now being called upon to skirt the land of Edom on their journey to the Promised Land! **The problem with going around the border of Edom meant: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- A long, hard walk...
- Many hills and valley...
- Even more burning desert...

Their song of redemption and victory turned to grumbling and complaining! Sound familiar? Aren't we often just like that? Amid the problems of Edom it is easy to forget how bad Egypt really was!

Complaining was nothing new to the Israelites but here we find their murmuring took a new twist.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE) Before their complaints had been directed at Aaron and Moses, but now they spoke out blatantly against God! Numbers 21:5 (NKJV) ***“And the people spoke against God and against Moses: “Why have you brought us up out of Egypt to die in the wilderness? For there is no food and no water, and our soul loathes this worthless bread.”*** Can you imagine such ingratitude after nearly forty years of continuous tender loving care? This was the epitome of rebellion!

Because of the people's rebellion, God sent judgment upon them! Numbers 21:6 (NKJV) ***“The LORD sent fiery serpents among the people, and they bit the people; and many of the people of Israel died.”*** **Sin always sets in motion some unavoidable consequences: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Sin must always be punished...** Romans 6:23 (NKJV) ***“The wages of sin is death, but the gift***

of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.”

- **Un-confessed sin must always be punished...**

As merciful and kind as God is, He cannot simply overlook un-confessed sin, He is committed to bringing the very nature of sin to justice!

- **The law of sowing and reaping is an unchangeable law which also; and especially includes sin...** Galatians 6:7-8 (NKJV) *“Do not be deceived, God is not mocked; for whatever a man sows, that he will also reap. ⁸For he who sows to his flesh will of the flesh reap corruption, but he who sows to the Spirit will of the Spirit reap everlasting life.”*

- **Sin is an affront to God’s holiness...** When the holiness of God is insulted, judgment will always follow! Based on what God chose to do here to bring justice to the assault on His holiness, I would say God was ticked!

Why did God send serpents? From Genesis to Revelation the serpent is a symbol of Satan. It would seem to me that God was graphically teaching the Israelites that they would reap what they had sown! If they followed sin, sin would kill them.

This judgment is a lesson for us too. Paul refers to this account in his advice to the Christians at Corinth. ¹ Corinthians 10:9-11 (NKJV) *“Let us not tempt Christ,*

as some of them also tempted, and were destroyed by serpents; ¹⁰nor complain, as some of them also complained, and were destroyed by the destroyer.

¹¹Now all these things happened to them as examples, and they were written for our admonition, upon whom the ends of the ages have come.”

When we become aware of sin in our lives and are quick to be willing to deal with it in repentance, we can alleviate the negative consequences which sin can bring. 1 Corinthians 11:31 (NKJV) *“If we would judge ourselves, we would not be judged.”* The lesson of this scripture is not judgment but salvation.

Numbers 21:7-9 (NKJV) *“Therefore the people came to Moses, and said, “We have sinned, for we have spoken against the LORD and against you; pray to the LORD that He take away the serpents from us.” So Moses prayed for the people. ⁸Then the LORD said to Moses, “Make a fiery serpent, and set it on a pole; and it shall be that everyone who is bitten, when he looks at it, shall live.” ⁹So Moses made a bronze serpent, and put it on a pole; and so it was, if a serpent had bitten anyone, when he looked at the bronze serpent, he lived.”*

The serpent of brass was a picture of the Lord Jesus Christ, the ultimate cure for sin! **When the people** who had been bitten simply **turned their eyes on the brazen serpent, their life would be miraculously saved: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **They were not told to prepare a vaccine for healing...** they were told to follow one simple instruction... Numbers 21:8 (NKJV) ***“Make a fiery serpent, and set it on a pole; and it shall be that everyone who is bitten, when he looks at it, shall live.”***
- **They were not told to fight off the serpents...** Humanly speaking, that approach probably seemed quite logical or even plausible.
- **They were not told to mount a massive “kill the snakes” campaign...** The fact is, this kind of predicament could not be overcome by human ingenuity!

The healing for the snakebite of sin has already been provided! Isaiah 1:18-19 (NKJV) ***“Come now, and let us reason together,” Says the LORD, “Though your sins are like scarlet, They shall be as white as snow; Though they are red like crimson, They shall be as wool.”***¹⁹ ***If you are willing and obedient, You shall eat the good of the land.”***

You cannot kill enough snakes in your life to please God! You must come as you are!

God did not ask the people for any kind of repayment, He just asked them to look by faith, upon the brazen serpent! John 3:16-17 (NKJV) ***“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that***

whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life. ¹⁷*“For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but that the world through Him might be saved.”* What a picture of Grace! Grace does not say “DO”, it says “DONE”!

There are several parallels between the Brazen Serpent and the Lord Jesus Christ: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **The serpent was lifted upon the pole...** The Lord Jesus Christ was lifted upon the cross!
- **The requirement for a healing vaccine was to look on the serpent by faith...** The requirement for salvation is Faith! Romans 10:9-10 (NKJV) *“If you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you will be saved. ¹⁰For with the heart one believes unto righteousness, and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation.”*
- **Works could not save them from the poison of the snakes...** Works will not save us either! Ephesians 2:8-9 (NKJV) *“For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, lest anyone should boast.”*

SKIT: (The props for the skit and the actors get set up as the following statements are made by the Pastor)

Suppose an Israelite had been bitten by one of those fiery serpents. He knew that if left to his own resources the snake bite would be fatal! He had watched as others had succumbed to the venom of the dreaded snakes!

He had heard of the Brazen Serpent! He knew people had simply looked at it and survived. But he thought it was a foolish idea.

(The pole with the Brazen Serpent is set up, and a snake bite victim is in position) A friend comes to him and says, “*Why don’t you look at Moses’ Brazen Serpent?*” He gives him his testimony, “*I looked and lived!*” The snake bite victim replies, “*I cannot bring myself to believe a snake on a pole can do anything for me!*” He is afraid someone will think he is foolish! His friend explains, “*This is your only hope! No one has survived the snake bite except those who have looked at the brazen serpent!*” The snake bite victim thinks about it for a while and then decides he will go out and see if he can find some medicine which will reverse the venom of the snake. He goes through the audience begging people to tell him where he can get help. He finds no help and with his strength failing, returns to his friend and lies down. His friend once again tries to get him to look at the brazen serpent on the pole, but he is not quite ready yet! He’s going to wait until he feels better. Now he feels that he is too sick for the brazen serpent to do him any good, besides

that, he knew someone who looked at the snake and lived, who he knew to be a hypocrite! The man dies!
(Some people come in with a stretcher and carry the snake bite victim out.)

The Pastor say's "What would you think of such a man? He was foolish, yet so many today are doing the exact same thing!"

Another snake bite victim enters and after being convinced the brazen serpent can help him, he looks upon it and lives! The entire casts of actors rejoice because of the miracle!

The Pastor say's "The call from the Brazen Serpent was 'look and live,' the call from the cross is 'look and live!' The serpent was their ONLY hope and Jesus is our ONLY hope!"

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